

break a model, then fix it

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workshop plan · rootconf 2026



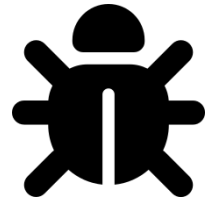
portrait photo goes here

three hours. everyone leaves having **broken a model on purpose.**

this is not the workshop. **this is how the room spends the time.**



———— **they build it.** forty lines, one test that has to go green.



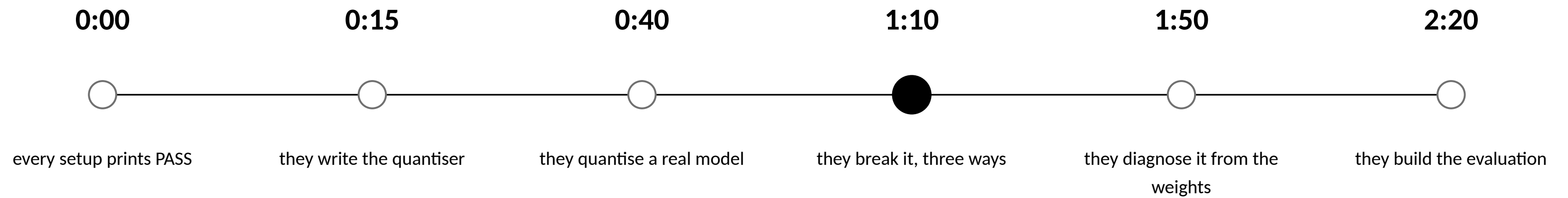
———— **they break it.** three ways, each a one line change.



———— **they diagnose it.** from the weights, not from the output.



———— **they measure it.** an eval that catches what accuracy misses.



three hours. **the last forty minutes are the overflow**, if i lose time earlier i demo the eval instead of building it

the three breaks are all bugs i shipped.



the dead layer. every weight rounds to zero.



the outlier clip. one weight in ten thousand did not fit.



the silent one. it stopped answering and the score went up.

100%

of weights in a wide layer round to
zero at three bits

7.47

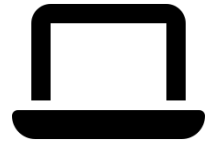
the largest weight in a checkpoint
everyone assumes is bounded by one

1.2%

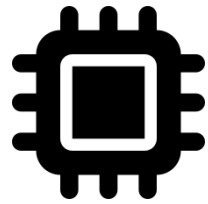
of prompts a broken model still
answered, while scoring 100

every diagnosis is a **histogram** or a **counter**.

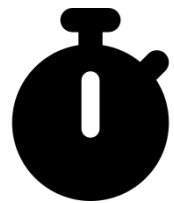
nobody has to read generated text. **that's the part that goes wrong in a room.**



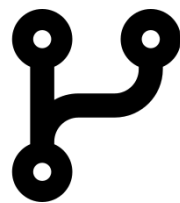
———— runs on a laptop. python, pytorch, numpy, matplotlib.



———— **no gpu.** no cloud account. no dataset download.



———— under ten minutes of actual compute, all of it on cpu.



———— an identical colab notebook, cell for cell, as the fallback.

a branch per stage. **nobody gets stranded.**

each stage ends on a test. **green means move on.** that replaces me asking thirty people whether they're done.

if i lose time early, the last hour is **the thing that gives**. i demo the eval instead of building it.

a quantiser

forty lines they wrote and understand

three checks

runnable against any checkpoint they have on
monday

an eval pattern

capability paired with liveness, useful well past
quantisation

what they walk out with

three hours, thirty people, one helper past that
the setup script **in the joining email**, a week ahead
january, not november — but november if you need it

**will my checkpoint survive this, and how would i know if it
hadn't?**